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**SAHAL ABDUL SAMAD, WHO HAS LONG BEEN
ADMIRER FOR HIS DRIBBLING AND CLOSE
CONTROL, NEVER REALLY FOUND A REGULAR
RUN AS A NO. 10 PLAYER AT KERALA BLASTERS**
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PICT: RITU RAJ KONWAR

and five-foreigner rule (2014 to 2020) prompted teams to look abroad for players who could raise the technical level of their side. This over-reliance on foreigners was not only for centre-forward and attacking midfield roles but also central midfield.

Historically, ISL teams have either deployed experienced foreigners in a two-man pivot in the midfield or paired a foreigner with an up-and-coming Indian in front of the back four.

The average age of an Indian midfielder in the league is 23.96, while for an overseas midfielder, it is close to 32. Therefore, the latter tends to dictate proceedings as the central figure while the domestic midfielder plays a supporting role.

In recent years, successful teams in the ISL have followed this trend, such as: Mumbai City ('23-'24) — Lalengmawia Ralte-Yoell van Nieff/Alberto Noguera, ATK Mohun Bagan (now called Mohun Bagan Super Giant) ('22-'23) — Carl McHugh-Glan Martins/Puitea, Hyderabad FC ('21-'22) — Joao Victor-Souvik Chakrabarti/Hitesh Sharma/Sahil Tavora and Mumbai City ('20-'21) — Jahouh-Raynier Fernandes/Rowlin Borges.

However, success with an all-Indian double pivot is very rare. In the 2021-22 season, Scotsman Owen Coyle took Jamshedpur FC to the ISL Shield title with the pairing of Pronay Halder and Jitendra Singh. And with Chennaiyin FC in 2019-20, when it finished runner-up, Coyle preferred Anirudh Thapa to be partnered